Photography & Lighting

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Framing & angles

Extreme wide shot extreme wide shot, a tiny lone figure in a vast landscape, the place dominating the frame

Wide shot wide shot, the full figure small in the frame with the surroundings clearly visible

Full shot full shot, head to toe, the figure filling the frame height

Cowboy shot cowboy shot, framed from mid-thigh up

Medium shot medium shot, framed from the waist up

Medium close-up medium close-up, framed from mid-chest up

Close-up close-up portrait, the face filling the frame, top of the head slightly cropped

Extreme close-up extreme close-up on the eyes, filling the frame edge to edge

Insert shot insert shot, a tight detail of hands holding a steaming coffee cup, no face visible

Two-shot two-shot, two people facing each other, framed from the waist up

Over-the-shoulder over-the-shoulder shot, the foreground shoulder dark and out of focus, the person facing camera in sharp focus

POV shot first-person POV shot, the viewer's own hands holding a paper map at the bottom of the frame, the road ahead beyond it

Eye level eye-level camera angle, straight-on and neutral

Low angle low-angle shot looking up at the subject, sky behind, verticals converging upward, heroic and imposing

High angle high-angle shot looking down on the subject, ground filling the background, the figure small and vulnerable

Bird's-eye view bird's-eye view shot straight down from directly above, flat graphic composition, long shadows on the ground

Worm's-eye view worm's-eye view from ground level looking straight up, tall shapes converging toward the sky

Dutch angle Dutch angle, the camera tilted about 20 degrees so the horizon slants, uneasy and off-balance

Aerial shot aerial drone photograph from high above, the landscape reduced to patterns of texture and color

Flat lay flat lay, objects arranged neatly at right angles on a plain surface, shot straight down, soft even shadows

Rule of thirds rule-of-thirds composition, the subject on the left third line, horizon on the lower third

Centered symmetry perfectly centered symmetrical composition, one-point perspective, the subject dead center

Leading lines strong leading lines from the foreground converging on the subject

Negative space minimalist composition with vast negative space, a small subject in the lower corner of an empty frame

Frame within a frame frame within a frame, the subject seen through a dark stone archway

Foreground layering layered depth: out-of-focus foreground grasses, the subject sharp in the midground, mountains fading in the background

Lead room generous lead room, the subject on the left facing right into open space

Low horizon very low horizon, a vast dramatic sky filling four fifths of the frame

Mirror reflection mirror-still water reflecting the scene, the waterline across the center of the frame

Lens & focus

Ultra-wide (14–16mm) shot on an ultra-wide 14mm lens, exaggerated perspective, the foreground looming and the background tiny

Wide (24mm) shot on a 24mm wide-angle lens, the subject in context with lots of environment, deep perspective

35mm shot on a 35mm lens, natural documentary perspective

50mm (normal) shot on a 50mm lens, natural undistorted perspective

85mm (portrait) shot on an 85mm portrait lens, flattering facial proportions, background compressed and softly blurred

Telephoto (200mm+) shot from far away on a 400mm telephoto lens, extreme compression, an enormous sun directly behind the subject

Macro macro photograph at 1:1 magnification, a dewdrop on a leaf filling the frame, razor-thin depth of field

Fisheye fisheye lens, strong barrel distortion, curved horizon, skate-video look

Tilt-shift tilt-shift miniature effect, a town seen from above with only a thin band in focus, saturated toy-like colors

Anamorphic shot on anamorphic lenses, 2.39:1 widescreen, oval bokeh and horizontal blue lens flares

Shallow depth of field shallow depth of field, shot wide open at f/1.4, the subject tack-sharp against a creamy blurred background

Deep focus deep focus at f/16, everything sharp from the foreground to the horizon

Bokeh large round bokeh balls from string lights in the background

Swirly bokeh vintage Helios 44 swirly bokeh, the background spinning in a ring around the subject

Split diopter split-diopter shot: a face in the near foreground and a figure far in the background, both in sharp focus, with a soft seam between

Long exposure long exposure of 60 seconds, silky misty water and streaked clouds, the pier perfectly sharp

Light trails long-exposure night shot, red and white car light trails streaking along the road

Panning panning shot at 1/30s, the cyclist sharp and the background smeared into horizontal motion streaks

Frozen motion high-speed photograph at 1/8000s, the splash frozen in midair, every droplet crystal sharp

Intentional camera movement intentional camera movement, a vertical swipe through an autumn birch forest, painterly streaks of color

Double exposure double exposure, a person's profile silhouette filled with a misty pine forest and mountains, pale background

Lens flare natural lens flare from the sun, a chain of soft hexagonal ghosts and a warm haze

Vignette strong natural vignette, corners falling off into darkness

Chromatic aberration visible chromatic aberration, purple and green fringing on high-contrast edges

Halation & bloom Black Pro-Mist 1/4 diffusion filter, highlights blooming into soft halos, slightly lifted blacks

Soft focus soft-focus glow, a dreamy haze over the highlights, old Hollywood glamour

Polarizing filter shot with a circular polarizer, deep blue sky, no glare on the water, rich saturated color

Sunstar sun peeking past the edge of a tree, a crisp sunstar with sharp rays at f/16

Prism effect shot through a glass prism, a soft rainbow refraction and a mirrored ghost along the left edge of the frame

Shooting through shot through out-of-focus foreground leaves, soft green blur framing the subject, voyeuristic

Lighting

Hard light hard direct light from a single small source, crisp sharp-edged shadows, high contrast

Soft light soft diffused light from a large window, gentle gradual shadows wrapping around the subject

Front light flat front lighting from directly behind the camera, minimal shadows

Side light strong side light from the left at 90 degrees, half the subject in shadow, revealing texture

Backlight strong backlight from behind the subject, a bright glowing rim outlining the edges, contre-jour

Top light hard top light from directly overhead, deep shadows in the eye sockets, moody and severe

Under light eerie under-lighting from below, shadows climbing upward, unsettling

Silhouette pure black silhouette against a bright sunset sky, no detail in the subject

Rembrandt lighting Rembrandt lighting: key light 45 degrees to the left and above, a small triangle of light on the shadowed cheek

Loop lighting loop lighting: key light 30 degrees to the left and slightly above, a small nose shadow angled toward the mouth

Butterfly lighting butterfly lighting: key light high and directly in front, a small symmetrical shadow under the nose, sculpted cheekbones

Split lighting split lighting: hard key light at 90 degrees to the left, exactly half the face in deep shadow

Clamshell lighting clamshell beauty lighting: soft key above and a reflector below, almost shadowless skin, double catchlights

Ring light ring light lighting, even shadowless front light, ring-shaped catchlights in the eyes

Rim light strong rim light from behind, a thin bright edge tracing the hair, jaw and shoulders against a dark background

Catchlights clear window-shaped catchlights in both eyes at the 10 o'clock position

Three-point lighting classic three-point lighting: soft key from the left, gentle fill from the right, back light rimming the hair

High-key high-key lighting, bright white background, soft even light, minimal shadows, airy and clean

Low-key low-key lighting, a single soft light from the side, deep black background, most of the subject falling into shadow

Chiaroscuro chiaroscuro lighting like a Dutch Golden Age still life, one warm window light carving objects out of deep darkness

Practical lights lit only by practical lights in the scene: a warm table lamp casting a pool of light, the rest of the room in dusky shadow

Colored gels dual-color gel lighting, hot magenta from the left and electric cyan from the right, dark background

Neon light neon-lit night street, pink and cyan neon signs reflecting in rain-soaked pavement, deep blue shadows

Window-blind shadows hard light through venetian blinds casting diagonal striped shadows across the face and wall, film noir

Direct flash harsh direct on-camera flash, bright flat-lit face, hard shadow behind on the wall, dark falloff, candid party snapshot

Dragging the shutter slow-sync flash, dragging the shutter: the subject frozen by flash with streaks of colored ambient light swirling around them

Light painting long-exposure light painting, a ring of spinning steel-wool sparks around a dark silhouette at night

Candlelight lit only by candlelight from below and in front, warm amber glow, darkness falling off quickly

Natural light & weather

Golden hour golden hour, low warm sun skimming across the scene, long soft shadows, glowing rim light

Blue hour blue hour, deep cobalt twilight sky, warm glowing windows contrasting with the cool blue

Midday sun harsh midday sun overhead, short hard shadows directly beneath, saturated summer color

Alpenglow alpenglow just after sunset, the mountain peaks glowing rose pink above cool blue valleys

Moonlight moonlit night, cool silver-blue light, a glittering moon path on the water, stars overhead

Milky Way night sky astrophotography of the Milky Way arching over a silhouetted landscape, thousands of stars, 20-second exposure

Overcast soft overcast daylight, an even white sky, shadowless and gentle, muted natural color

Fog & mist thick morning fog, layers of pine trees fading into white mist with distance, quiet and mysterious

God rays volumetric god rays streaming through the forest canopy, visible shafts of light in misty air

Dappled light dappled sunlight filtering through leaves, soft spots of light scattered across the subject and ground

Rain & wet streets rainy night, wet pavement mirroring the streetlights, visible rain streaks backlit by the lamps

Snowfall gentle snowfall, a pale white landscape with soft blue shadows, out-of-focus snowflakes in the foreground

Storm light dramatic storm light, sunlight breaking through under dark slate-grey clouds onto a vivid green landscape, a faint rainbow

Window light soft window light from the left, gentle falloff across the room, quiet Vermeer-like interior

Mixed lighting mixed lighting, cool blue twilight from the window on one side and warm tungsten lamplight on the other

Sodium streetlight night street under sodium-vapor streetlights, everything washed in monochrome amber orange, murky shadows

Fluorescent light flat overhead fluorescent tube lighting, slightly green cast, sterile and institutional

Screen glow face lit only by the cool blue glow of a laptop screen in a dark room, late at night

Film & color

Kodak Portra 400 shot on Kodak Portra 400 film, soft natural contrast, warm skin tones, gentle pastel color, fine grain

Kodak Ektar 100 shot on Kodak Ektar 100, vivid saturated color, deep blue sky, ultra-fine grain

Kodak Gold 200 shot on Kodak Gold 200, warm golden-yellow cast, nostalgic 90s snapshot color, visible grain

Kodachrome shot on Kodachrome 64 slide film, rich reds and yellows, deep cyan-blue sky, high contrast, mid-century color

Fujichrome Velvia 50 shot on Fujichrome Velvia 50, hyper-saturated greens and blues, punchy contrast, landscape slide film

Fujicolor Superia shot on Fujicolor Superia 400, cool cyan-green cast, fresh greens, soft grain

CineStill 800T shot on CineStill 800T, night scene, red halation halos glowing around the lights, cool teal shadows, grain

Kodak Aerochrome Kodak Aerochrome infrared film, foliage turned vivid pink and red, surreal false color

LomoChrome Purple shot on LomoChrome Purple, greens turned lavender and violet, blues shifted to teal, dreamy color-shifted film

Kodak Tri-X 400 shot on Kodak Tri-X 400 pushed to 1600, gritty high-contrast black and white, coarse grain, deep blacks

Fine-grain black & white fine-grain black and white on Ilford Pan F 50, smooth silky tonality, rich mid-greys, crisp detail

Black & white infrared black-and-white infrared photograph, foliage glowing white, near-black sky, dreamlike halation

Polaroid vintage Polaroid SX-70 instant photo, faded dreamy colors, soft focus, white border with a thick bottom edge

Disposable camera disposable camera snapshot, harsh on-camera flash, dark background, warm grainy film, orange date stamp in the corner

Toy camera Holga toy camera photo, square frame, heavy vignette, soft blurry edges, shifted saturated color

Light leaks warm red and orange light leaks bleeding in from the right edge of the frame, film burn

Expired film shot on expired film, faded magenta color shift, lifted muddy blacks, heavy grain, unpredictable color

Cross-processing cross-processed slide film, harsh contrast, acid yellow-green highlights and blue shadows, late-90s magazine look

Wet plate collodion wet plate collodion tintype portrait, silvery warm-grey tones, dark ragged edges with chemical pour marks, 1860s look

Cyanotype cyanotype print, white fern and leaf silhouettes on deep Prussian blue paper, brushy hand-coated edges

Super 8 Super 8 film still, heavy grain, warm faded home-movie color, soft focus, rounded frame corners

VHS camcorder VHS camcorder footage, smeared bleeding colors, scan lines, a tracking glitch band, white on-screen date overlay

Early digital camera early-2000s digital point-and-shoot photo, harsh flash, cool white balance, clipped highlights, CCD sensor look, date stamp

Medium format shot on medium format film with a Hasselblad 500C/M, square 6x6 frame, smooth tonality, gentle shallow focus

Teal and orange teal and orange color grade, teal shadows and warm orange skin tones, blockbuster look

Bleach bypass bleach bypass grade, desaturated silvery color, harsh contrast, gritty war-film look

Faded matte faded matte grade, lifted milky blacks, soft low contrast, slightly desaturated

Split toning split-toned grade, warm cream highlights and cool blue shadows, muted overall

Sepia sepia-toned monochrome photograph, warm brown and cream tones, antique feel

Pastel grade soft pastel color grade, pink, mint and powder-blue tones, gentle low contrast

Vivid saturated vivid hyper-saturated color, punchy reds, yellows and blues, glossy and bright

Genres & references

Editorial portrait editorial magazine portrait, bold orange seamless backdrop, crisp studio lighting, confident direct gaze

Street photography candid street photography, a lone pedestrian stepping into a shaft of hard sunlight between deep shadows, 35mm

Documentary documentary photojournalism, candid and unstaged, available light, grainy black and white, Magnum style

Product photography premium product photography, the bottle centered on a soft gradient seamless, strip-light rim highlights, subtle reflection below

Food photography dark and moody food photography from overhead, a bowl of ramen on slate, side window light, scattered herbs and chopsticks

Architectural photography architectural photography with perfectly corrected verticals, a brutalist concrete facade, hard sun carving deep geometric shadows, clean blue sky

Interior photography interior design photography, wide 24mm view straight on, perfectly vertical lines, soft daylight from tall windows, calm minimal styling

Wildlife photography wildlife photography with a 600mm lens, a grey heron standing in shallow water, tack-sharp eye, background melted into smooth green blur

Cinematic film still cinematic film still, 2.39:1 letterbox, a lone figure on a rain-slicked street under a streetlight, teal and orange grade, anamorphic

Fine-art conceptual surreal fine-art conceptual photograph, a lone wooden door standing open in a misty field, warm light pouring through it

Ansel Adams in the spirit of Ansel Adams: majestic black-and-white mountain landscape, full tonal range from deep black to bright white, dramatic clouds, large-format detail

Henri Cartier-Bresson in the spirit of Henri Cartier-Bresson: a decisive-moment black-and-white street photograph, a man leaping over a puddle, his reflection mirrored in the water, 50mm

Saul Leiter in the spirit of Saul Leiter: painterly color street photograph through a rain-streaked window, large dark shapes filling the frame, a small red umbrella in falling snow, muted tones

Fan Ho in the spirit of Fan Ho: black-and-white Hong Kong alley, a single diagonal shaft of light through smoky air, a tiny lone figure in the beam, deep geometric shadows

William Eggleston in the spirit of William Eggleston: an everyday American interior in saturated dye-transfer color, a blood-red ceiling with a bare bulb and white wires

Martin Parr in the spirit of Martin Parr: saturated daylight-flash close-up of a dripping ice cream cone at a crowded seaside, garish color, humorous documentary

Gregory Crewdson in the spirit of Gregory Crewdson: cinematic suburban street at blue hour, every window glowing, a lone figure standing motionless on the lawn, faint mist, eerie stillness, staged like a film set

Todd Hido in the spirit of Todd Hido: a lone house at night with a single glowing window, murky foggy air under a sodium streetlight, seen through a misted car windshield

Hiroshi Sugimoto in the spirit of Hiroshi Sugimoto: minimalist black-and-white seascape, the horizon exactly centered, silky long-exposure sea and empty sky in soft greys

Roger Deakins in the spirit of Roger Deakins: a lone silhouetted figure walking through dense orange haze, single-source light, minimal composition, monumental scale

Wong Kar-wai & Christopher Doyle in the spirit of Wong Kar-wai and Christopher Doyle: step-printed motion smear, a figure blurred in a narrow neon-lit Hong Kong corridor, saturated green and red, shot through dirty glass

Wes Anderson in the style of a Wes Anderson film: a perfectly symmetrical pastel pink hotel facade, centered, flat frontal composition, candy-colored palette